

members were surprised when the Turner fetched \$320,000 is an understatement. Even the auctioneer, Leonard Joel in Melbourne, was taken aback, especially as the price was more than \$100,000 over the reserve. According to John Dwyer at Joel's, James Alfred Turner was a Victorian artist who painted mainly sentimental bush scenes.

"He has always been shunned by institutions and academics and I think his contemporaries, especially the Heidelberg School painters, thought him something of an amateur."

Dwyer was reluctant to say more but he did agree that the painting's connection with the Melbourne Club had bumped up the price. He also declined to reveal the name of the buyer but *Good Weekend* has discovered it was

a Perth businessman (not Robert Holmes à Court).

Although the amount received was encouraging, the club still has to find another \$400,000. Fortunately it has until December 1986 before the repairs have to be completed.

But the problem remains, where will the rest of the money come from? According to the October 4 letter, the Turner may not be the only painting to go under the auctioneer's hammer. "In deciding upon a sale of assets," reads the letter, "the committee considered that the best source of funds was the disposal by auction and/or by private treaty of some paintings in the club's art collection."

The letter, which is signed by the president, Keith Sinclair, stresses that the committee of management will

honour all conditions attached to gifts and will seek permission from any member donor or family of a deceased member before selling.

But the words "some paintings" have concerned a few members of the club, which houses works by the likes of Streeton, McCubbin and Rupert Bunny. "Quite frankly," said one member, "the Turner wasn't the nicest painting in the club. But I would be very upset — and I think a lot of other members would too — if a great wad of valuable paintings disappeared off the walls."

The club secretary, Keith Hendy, declined to comment on the sale of the Turner or the fire safety repair work. The president, Keith Sinclair, also declined to comment, saying that these were private matters confined to club members only. □

UNSPORTING HOLD~UPS DELAY GALLERY OF SPORT

By KEITH DUNSTAN

AH YES, of all the 5,000 projects in Victoria's 150th year unquestionably the strawberry on the ice-cream was to be the Gallery of Sport.

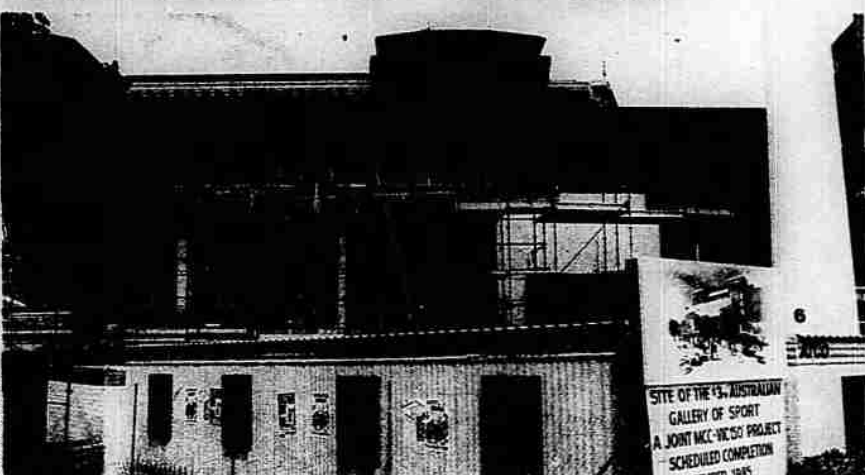
We feel more deeply, more passionately about sport, than even money. Well, almost. So we thought what a glorious tourist attraction for Melbourne — Gallery to the Arts in St Kilda Road, Gallery to Sport in Richmond Park.

But, alas, it has had to fight battles — against the National Trust, against the city council and above all, against Norm. The trust felt it destroyed the character of the beloved old MCG, the council thought it was park-grabbing too close to the main building and Norm Gallagher didn't like John Cain.

The Gallery of Sport is being built for nigh on \$3 million just outside the members' entrance at the Melbourne Cricket Ground. It will be a museum and a gallery, covering 19 sports, everything from cricket and football through to squash and lawn bowls.

I believe John Landy, for example, has donated the spikes he used to run his first four-minute mile. There's a hall of fame which will kick off with 120 illustrious greats — Don Bradman, Dawn Fraser, Robert de Castella, Hubert Opperman, Jimmy Carruthers, Frank Sedgman, that sort of thing.

The theory was that it would be opened during the 150th year, before the end of last month. There were months approving the niceties of the design and whether it would fit into the park and whether it would be in harmony with the



old members' stand. Then came the building of the lights at the MCG. There was the demarcation dispute with the ironworkers and the AWU, the BLF and Norm Gallagher; \$15 million worth of projects at the MCG were declared black.

In January/February there were delays to MCG projects because of over-award payments. Eventually workers received promise of over-award payments of \$84 a week, two free tickets to VFL finals, safety boots and overalls. That was settled in April. Then, in July, there were further stoppages over the jailing of Norm Gallagher.

In August, September/October there was splendid progress, lots of concrete poured, so much that on October 23 Premier John Cain was able to lay a foundation stone. He announced that the gallery would be a lasting memento to Victoria's 150th and enhance the historic significance and great traditions

The Victorian Gallery of Sport

associated with the MCG. John Cain, "the enemy," had invaded the site. By walking on to the site Mr Cain had made it "unsafe." Bryce Thomas, assistant secretary of the Melbourne Cricket Club told us, that if a site is unsafe under the award, the workers must still be paid. The BLF members were not paid, so a strike was on again. They did not return until Thursday, November 14.

They worked two days but not on the following Monday. Now they were not working Mondays, only Tuesday-to-Friday. This was to point up Norm's battle then for the 35-hour week.

We consulted a despairing Stan Evans. When will we see the completed Gallery of Sport.

No hope before April 1986, said Stan.

An equally sad Bryce Thomas said delays on MCG projects had cost the club an extra \$1.5 million. □